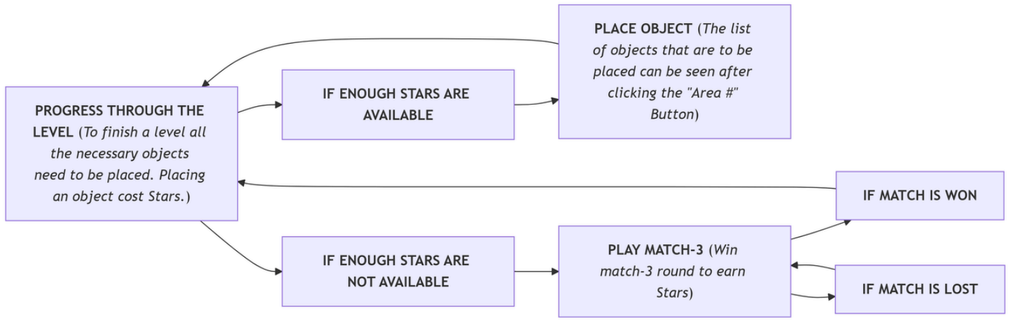
ROYAL MATCH DECONSTRUCTION

THE CORE GAMEPLAY LOOP



GAME PROGRESSION

Royal Match follows a 2 Layered progression system that separates the intense Match-3 Puzzle solving from long-term meta progression...

- **Primary Gameplay Layer:** It is a match-3 level sequence. Players complete objectives within a limited number of moves to advance to the next level. Upon beating a level, they earn stars and coins. Stars are the meta-currency used to place objects to complete renovation tasks and unlock new areas within King Robert's castle
- **Meta Progression Layer:** The meta-game is structured around thematic areas that serve as progression milestone. Each area contains a set of levels with unique themes and renovation objectives. Players unlock new areas sequentially by completing all tasks in their current area.

To put it simply, when the player starts the game he is gets an empty room of king Robert's castle which is to be renovated. To fix the rooms, he has to place all the required objects in the room (which is provided to the player in a list format). To place the objects he needs Stars, which he can gain by winning a match-3 round. Once the player finishes his work in a particular room, he moves on to the next room (the rooms are the main levels which would guide the meta progression).

PACING & LEVEL DESIGN

Royal Match's level design is engineered around a deliberate difficulty rhythm that oscillates between tension and recovery. The game alternates easy and challenging levels, maintaining rhythm without overwhelming beginners. Early sessions are calming and accessible, difficulty increases gradually, and special "King's Nightmare" stages act as milestone challenges.

Analysis of the first 100 levels reveals a precisely structured learning curve:

- five worlds of 20 levels each, with nine bonus "victory laps" every tenth level.
- 11 new block types introduced between levels 1 and 91, and four boosters unlocked at levels 8, 14, 17, and 19.
- Normal levels require approximately 1.2 attempts on average with 23–30 moves allotted.
- Eight designated hard levels (levels 39, 45, 49, 55, 65, 75, 85, 95) average 1.6 attempts
- Five super-hard peaks (levels 59, 69, 79, 89, 99) push toward 2.5 attempts.

Notably, the move count tightens as players progress: levels 1–20 allow 30–38 moves, levels 21–60 allow 25–30, and levels 61–100 allow 23–27, increasing decision density by roughly 20% by the end of the first hundred levels.

There is a prevalence of near-miss and near-loss moments. Playliner's study of 500 levels found that Royal Match contains nearly twice as many near-loss moments compared to Candy Crush Saga and twice as many almost-win moments compared to Homescapes. When a player loses a level with only a few goals remaining, they are highly likely to purchase extra moves or boosters to continue.

A key mechanical driver of this pacing is the Super Light Ball, introduced at level 292. Players must win 10 consecutive levels to activate it. Once active, the Light Ball booster doubles in power, clearing all items of two colors instead of one. The Super Light Ball remains active across subsequent levels until the player fails, at which point it resets and must be re-earned through another 10-win streak. This mechanic creates a powerful streak-based reward loop that simultaneously incentivizes consecutive wins, amplifies the emotional sting of failure, and makes the purchase of extra moves on a difficult level feel like protecting an accumulated investment rather than simply buying a continue. The Super Light Ball has been credited as a major revenue driver, with one analysis attributing a 1.5× increase in revenue to its introduction.

Source:

- https://www.linkedin.com/posts/aslashcev_royal-match-level-design-insights-together-share-7351918247048278018-fZOp/
- https://www.linkedin.com/posts/oxana-fomina-06910b2_royalmatch-f2p-mobilegames-share-7024355829701046272-RsCl/

MONETISATION

- **No Ads:** Royal Match operates on a pure in-app purchase model with zero advertising. There are no banner ads, no rewarded video, and no interstitial interruptions.
  This design choice is deliberate: it preserves the player's sense of immersion and trust, while concentrating all monetisation pressure into moments of maximum emotional vulnerability.
- **No Ads:** Royal Match operates on a pure in-app purchase model with zero advertising. There are no banner ads, no rewarded video, and no interstitial interruptions.
- **Sunk Cost Loop:** The monetisation system is built on a economy designed to create a persistent deficit between currency earnings and the cost of continuing play.
  Players earn approximately 20–60 coins per successful level clear, but the cost to continue a failed level without restarting begins at 900 coins and escalates to 3,900 coins on subsequent attempts. This is intentional, it ensures that players who repeatedly fail will inevitably hit the real-money exchange wall.
  Also the escalating continue cost also creates a sunk-cost loop: having already invested 900 coins in a failed attempt, the player is psychologically primed to invest more rather than walk away and lose that investment.
- **A huge range of Prices:** In-app purchase packages range from ₹199 to $9,900.
- **Emotional Defenciveness:** The game also uses loss aversion strategically: Streak systems, and Milestone rewards are framed not as purchases of moves, but as protection of progress already earned. This reframing makes spending feel defensive rather than indulgent.
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- **Events:** Event-related monetization further amplifies conversion by mixing competition, social pressure, and spending urgency. The game runs events nearly continuously. These events create multiple overlapping timelines of urgency, each with its own reward structure and spend triggers.

RETENTION

- **Two-Layered Retention Mechanism:** Royal Match's retention strategy operates on two complementary elements: a lightweight meta-game that boosts dopamine and a dense calendar that provides daily reasons to return.
- **Emotional Investment:** The meta-game's retention power lies in its emotional investment mechanics.
  By decorating King Robert's castle room by room, players create a visual record of their progress that feels personal.
  This progression of internal identity is a sophisticated retention mechanism that operates beneath the surface of the match-3 loop.
- **Daily Engagement System:** Daily jackpot events are a staple of Royal Match's live-service strategy. These events are intentionally brief, typically solvable in a player's first session of the day, and offer substantial prize pools with light competitive elements.
- **Competitive Aspect:** Though it is a casual game it has competitive elements, such as Leaderboards, Streak systems, etc. which helps to keep the player more immersed and engaged in the game for longer amount of time.
- **Giveaways:** Boosters, currency, and bonuses are distributed generously through events, tournaments, and chests, making players feel their time investment is acknowledged. The game maintains at least two releases per month across 2024–2025, introducing 49 new areas, 25 new puzzle mechanics, and 13 new event types over that period. This live-ops discipline ensures that even long-term players encounter consistent novelty.

Source:

- https://medium.com/@arjundevb90/case-study-live-ops-in-royal-match-69da1982c084#1